

Share photos and customise your phone

Once you've begun stockpiling photos on your Windows Phone by capturing them with the internal camera, saving them from the Web, syncing them with your PC, or viewing them in online photo galleries, you may want to take the next logical steps. These include finding your favourite photos, sharing photos with others, and then customising Windows Phone in various ways with those photos. In this section, we examine all of these possibilities.

Finding Your Favourites

If you've spent any time managing and enjoying digital music over the years, you're probably familiar with the concept of a playlist, which is a way to organize a list of favourite songs so that you can play them back together at any time in the future. With pictures, Windows Phone supports the notion of a collection called the Favourites gallery. This gallery groups specially tagged, or identified, photos and lets you view them together regardless of their individual origins. So it works much like a playlist. It also works like the Favourites list in Internet Explorer (or the bookmarks you'll find in other browsers).

The Favourites gallery can be accessed from the first section in the Pictures hub, and if you just got your phone or haven't worked with this feature yet, it's highly probable that it's empty. (Otherwise, it's possible that your phone maker tagged some bundled photos as favourites.) Now it's time to add some favourites. There are two places you can save a favourite. First, in any photo gallery that contains locally saved pictures Camera Roll, Saved Pictures, or folders synced from your PC you can tap and hold on an image thumbnail to display a pop-up menu; choose Add to Favourites. Likewise, when you're viewing a photo—and, again, it needs to be a locally saved photo and not a web-based photo you can perform the same tap and hold action and choose Add to Favourites.

Once you've marked a number of photos this way, navigate to the main section of the Pictures hub and then tap Favourites. Here, you'll see a gallery of your favourite pictures, arranged in the order in which you marked them. You can interact with these photos in the same way that you do with photos in other photo galleries, but there is one important difference: Favourites is not a folder, and marking a photo as a favourite does not remove it from its original location. Instead, Favourites acts like a virtual folder in the desktop versions of Windows. That is, it contains links (or shortcuts) to the actual photos. It's a view, not a container.